Nguồn: Investor.gov — U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC)
Ngày truy cập: 30/10/2026. Mỗi mục bên dưới ghi URL gốc của trang.
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Investor.gov — Save and Invest (U.S. SEC)

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Save and Invest

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest

Here are a few important steps to help you define and meet your financial goals.

Figure Out Your Finances

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/figure-out-your-finances

Take an honest look at your entire financial situation — what you own and what you owe. This is a “net worth statement.” On one side, list what you own. These are your “ assets . ” On the other side, list what you owe. These are your “ liabilities ” or debts. Subtract your liabilities from your assets. If your assets are larger than your liabilities, you have a “positive” net worth. If your liabilities are larger than your assets, you have a “negative” net worth. You’ll want to update your “net worth statement” every year to keep track of how you are doing. Don’t be discouraged if you have a negative net worth -- following a financial plan will help you turn it into positive net worth. The next step is to keep track of your income and expenses. Write down what you and others in your family earn and spend each month,

and include a category for savings and investing. If you are spending all your income, and never have money to save or invest, start by cutting back on expenses. When you watch where you spend your money, you will be surprised how small everyday expenses can add up. Many people get into the habit of saving and investing by paying themselves first. An easy way to do this is to have your bank automatically deposit money from your paycheck into a savings or investment account.

Define Your Goals

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/define-your-goals

Knowing how to secure your financial well-being is one of the most important things you can do for yourself. You don't have to be a genius to do it. You just need to know a few basics, form a plan, and be ready to stick to it.

To end up where you want to be, you need a financial plan. Ask yourself what you want. List your most important goals first. Decide how many years you have to meet each specific goal, because when you save or invest, you'll need to find an option that fits your time frame. Here are some tools to help you decide how much you'll need to save for various needs.

- For more information, see: Saving and Investing: A Roadmap To Your Financial Security Through Saving and Investing .
- The Ballpark Estimate , created by the American Savings Education Council, can help you calculate what you'll need to save each year for retirement.
- The Financial Industry Regulatory Authority (FINRA) has a college savings calculator .

Save for a Rainy Day

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/save-rainy-day

Savings are usually put into safe places that allow you access to your money at any time. Examples include savings accounts, checking accounts, and certificates of deposit . Your money may be insured by the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation (FDIC) or National Credit Union Administration (NCUA). But there's a tradeoff between security and availability; your money earns a low interest rate. Most smart investors put enough money in savings to cover an emergency, like sudden unemployment. Some make sure they have up to six months of their income in savings so that they know it will absolutely be there for them when they need it. But how "safe" is a savings account if the interest it earns doesn't keep up with inflation? Let's say you save a dollar when it can buy a loaf of bread. But years later when you withdraw that dollar plus the interest you earned, it might only be able to

buy half a loaf. That is why many people put some of their money in savings, but look to investing so they can earn more over longer periods of time.

Pay Off Credit Cards or Other High Interest Debt

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/pay-credit-cards-or-other-high-interest

No investment strategy pays off as well as, or with less risk than, eliminating high interest debt. Most credit cards charge high interest rates -- as much as 18% or more - if you don't pay off your balance in full each month. If you owe money on your credit cards, the wisest thing you can do is pay off the balance in full as quickly as possible. Virtually no investment will give you returns to match an 18% interest rate on your credit card. That's why you're better off eliminating all credit card debt before investing. Once you've paid off your credit cards, you can budget your money and begin to save and invest. Here are some tips for avoiding credit card debt:

Put Away the Plastic

- Don't use a credit card unless you know you'll have the money to pay the bill when it arrives.

Know What You Owe

- It's easy to forget how much you've charged on your credit card. Every time you use a credit card, track how much you have spent and figure out how much you'll have to pay that month. If you know you won't be able to pay your balance in full, try to figure out how much you can pay each month and how long it'll take to pay the balance in full.

Pay Off the Card with the Highest Rate

- If you've got unpaid balances on several credit cards, you should first pay down the card that charges the highest rate. Pay as much as you can toward that debt each month until your balance is once again zero, while still paying the minimum on your other cards. The same advice goes for any other high-interest debt (about 8% or above), which does not offer any tax advantages.

Small Savings Add Up to Big Money

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/small-savings-add-big-money

How much does a daily candy bar cost? Would you believe $465.84? Or more? If you buy a candy bar every day for $1, it adds up to $365 a year. If you saved that $365 and put it into an investment that earns 5% a year, it would grow to $465.84 by the end of five years, and by the end of 30 years, to $1,577.50. That's the power of "compounding." With compound interest, you earn interest on the money you save and on the interest that money earns. Over time, even a small amount saved can add up to big money. If you buy on impulse, make a rule that you'll always wait 24 hours before buying anything. You may lose your desire to buy it after a day. Also, try emptying your pockets at the end of each day and putting spare change aside. You'll be surprised how quickly those nickels and dimes add up.

Understand What It Means to Invest

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/understand-what-it-means-invest

When investing, you have a greater chance of losing your money than when you save. Unlike FDIC-insured deposits, the money you invest in securities , mutual funds , and other similar investments are not federally insured. You could lose your "principal," which is the amount you've invested. That's true even if you purchase your investments through a bank. But when you invest, you also have the opportunity to earn more money. On the other hand, investing involves taking on some degree of risk.

Gauge Your Risk Tolerance

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/gauge-your-risk-tolerance

What are the best saving and investment products for you? The answer depends on when you will need the money, your goals, and whether you will be able to sleep at night if you purchase a risky investment (one where you could lose your principal). For instance, if you are saving for retirement, and you have 35 years before you retire, you may want to consider riskier investment products, knowing that if you stick to only the "savings" products or to less risky investment products, your money will grow too slowly. Or, given inflation and taxes, you may lose the purchasing power of your money. A frequent mistake people make is putting money they will not need for a very long time in investments that pay a low amount of interest. On the other hand, if you are saving for a short-term goal, five years or less, you don't want to choose risky investments, because when it's time to sell, you may have to take a loss.

Diversify Your Investments

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/diversify-your-investments

Diversification can be neatly summed up as, “Don’t put all your eggs in one basket.” The idea is that if one investment loses money, the other investments will make up for those losses. Diversification can’t guarantee that your investments won’t suffer if the market drops. But it can improve the chances that you won’t lose money, or that if you do, it won’t be as much as if you weren’t diversified. For more information on diversification, see Asset Allocation .

Learn About Investment Options

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/save-and-invest/learn-about-investment-options

While the SEC cannot recommend any particular investment product, a vast array of investment products exists, including stocks , mutual funds , corporate and municipal bonds , annuities , exchange-traded funds (ETFs), money market funds , and U.S . Treasury securities . Stocks, bonds, mutual funds and ETFs are the most common asset categories. These are among the asset categories you would likely choose from when investing in a retirement savings program or a college savings plan. Other asset categories include real estate, precious metals and other commodities , and private equity. Some investors may include these asset categories within a portfolio. Investments in these asset categories typically have category-specific risks. Before you make any investment, understand the risks of the investment and make sure the risks are appropriate for you . You’ll also want to understand the fees associated with the buying, selling, and holding the investment.

What is Risk?

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/what-risk

All investments involve some degree of risk . In finance, risk refers to the degree of uncertainty and/or potential financial loss inherent in an investment decision. In general, as investment risks rise, investors seek higher returns to compensate themselves for taking such risks.

Every saving and investment product has different risks and returns. Differences include: how readily investors can get their money when they need it, how fast their money will grow, and how safe their money will be. In this section, we are going to talk about a number of risks investors face. They include:

Business Risk

With a stock, you are purchasing a piece of ownership in a company. With a bond, you are loaning money to a company. Returns from both of these investments require that that the

company stays in business. If a company goes bankrupt and its assets are liquidated, common stockholders are the last in line to share in the proceeds. If there are assets, the company's bondholders will be paid first, then holders of preferred stock. If you are a common stockholder, you get whatever is left, which may be nothing.

If you are purchasing an annuity make sure you consider the financial strength of the insurance company issuing the annuity. You want to be sure that the company will still be around, and financially sound, during your payout phase.

Volatility Risk

Even when companies aren't in danger of failing, their stock price may fluctuate up or down. Large company stocks as a group, for example, have lost money on average about one out of every three years. Market fluctuations can be unnerving to some investors. A stock's price can be affected by factors inside the company, such as a faulty product, or by events the company has no control over, such as political or market events.

Inflation Risk

Inflation is a general upward movement of prices. Inflation reduces purchasing power, which is a risk for investors receiving a fixed rate of interest. The principal concern for individuals investing in cash equivalents is that inflation will erode returns.

Interest Rate Risk

Interest rate changes can affect a bond's value. If bonds are held to maturity the investor will receive the face value, plus interest. If sold before maturity, the bond may be worth more or less than the face value. Rising interest rates will make newly issued bonds more appealing to investors because the newer bonds will have a higher rate of interest than older ones. To sell an older bond with a lower interest rate, you might have to sell it at a discount.

Liquidity Risk

This refers to the risk that investors won't find a market for their securities, potentially preventing them from buying or selling when they want. This can be the case with the more complicated investment products. It may also be the case with products that charge a penalty for early withdrawal or liquidation such as a certificate of deposit (CD).

Are there any Guarantees?

The Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation (FDIC) – Savings accounts, insured money market accounts, and certificates of deposit (CDs) are generally viewed as safe because they are federally insured by FDIC. This independent agency of the federal government insures your money up to $250,000 per insured bank. It is important to note that the total is per

depositor not per account. But there's a tradeoff between security and availability; your money earns a low interest rate.

The FDIC insures deposits only. It does not insure securities, mutual funds, or similar types of investments that banks and thrift institutions may offer.

The National Credit Union Administration (NCUA) –The National Credit Union Share Insurance Fund (NCUSIF) is the federal fund created by Congress in 1970 to insure credit union member's deposits in federally insured credit unions. The Dodd -Frank Act permanently established NCUA's standard maximum share insurance amount at $250,000. NCUSIF is backed by the full faith and credit of the U.S. Government.

Securities Investors Protection Corporation (SIPC) – Securities you own, including mutual funds that are held for your account by a broker, or a bank's brokerage subsidiary, are not insured against loss in value. The value of your investments can go up or down depending on the demand for them in the market. The Securities Investors Protection Corporation (SIPC), a non government entity, replaces missing stocks and other securities in customer accounts held by SIPC member firm up to $500,000, including up to $250,000 in cash, if the firm fails. For more information see www.sipc.org .

Invest For Your Goals

Source: https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/invest-your-goals

From retirement planning, to saving for education, to simply building a nest egg, individual investors may have a wide range of goals they hope to achieve. A concrete investment plan can help keep you on track – and increase your chances of achieving your goals.

Questions you should ask yourself when developing your investment plan include:

- What goals do I want to achieve with my investments?
- How much do I need to invest to achieve my goals?
- How much can I afford to invest?
- What is my risk tolerance?
- What am I doing to protect myself from investment fraud?
- Have I checked my investment professional's background on Investor.gov ?

Below are some resources that can help you design your goals and create a plan that works for you:

- Investor Preparedness Checklist (PDF)
- Getting Started
- Retirement

- Military Retirement
- Saving for Education